

Name: _____

Date: _____

Score: _____ / 46

LEVEL B • WORKSHEET

Worksheet: The Platform and the Public Square

Comprehension + Vocabulary Tasks — Social Media, Politics, Identity and Truth

PART A — YES / NO / NOT GIVEN [7 marks] Questions 1–7

Do the following statements agree with the **claims of the writer** in the article?

Write your answers in the boxes below.

YES	<i>if the statement agrees with the claims of the writer</i>
NO	<i>if the statement contradicts the claims of the writer</i>
NOT GIVEN	<i>if it is impossible to say what the writer thinks about this</i>

1	Social media platforms are primarily motivated by a desire to inform and educate the public. Answer: _____
2	Research shows that false news stories spread faster and further than true ones on social media. Answer: _____
3	Political polarisation in modern democracies is caused exclusively by social media. Answer: _____
4	The writer believes that social media companies should bear no responsibility for the content on their platforms. Answer: _____
5	The European Union has introduced legislation that imposes obligations on large social media platforms. Answer: _____
6	The writer suggests that the concept of the 'authentic influencer' is fundamentally contradictory. Answer: _____
7	The writer is optimistic that social media companies will voluntarily reform their business models. Answer: _____

PART B — NOTE COMPLETION [9 marks] Questions 8–16

Complete the notes below using **ONE WORD ONLY** from the article for each answer.

Write your answers in the boxes below each question.

8 [The Business Model]

Social media platforms earn revenue through advertising, which depends on maximising user _____ on the platform.

9 [Surveillance Capitalism]

Shoshana Zuboff describes a system in which human _____ and behaviour are harvested as raw data and sold to advertisers.

10 [Filter Bubbles]

The filter bubble effect means users are progressively shown more content that _____ their existing beliefs.

11 [Echo Chambers]

In an echo chamber, _____ bias is systematically amplified, causing views to become more extreme over time.

12 [Misinformation vs Disinformation]

Misinformation is spread without _____ to deceive, while disinformation is deliberately false.

13 [Deepfakes]

Deepfakes are highly realistic synthetic videos that make public figures appear to say things they never _____.

14 [Radicalisation]

On YouTube, the recommendation algorithm has been shown to guide users towards progressively more _____ content.

15 [Identity and Social Media]

The mechanism linking social media to depression appears to be social _____ with others' curated highlight reels.

16 [Content Moderation]

The writer argues that content moderation decisions are not neutral — they are _____ decisions with profound consequences.

PART C – SHORT ANSWER QUESTIONS [6 marks] Questions 17–22

Answer these questions in your own words. Write **complete sentences**. Each answer is worth **1 mark**.

17. Why does the writer say that content triggering outrage spreads further than nuanced content on social media?

18. What is the difference between misinformation and disinformation, according to the article?

19. What did the Russian disinformation campaign of 2016 aim to achieve, according to the case study?

20. Why does the writer argue that social media companies cannot genuinely be described as 'neutral platforms'?

21. What does the writer mean when they say the influencer's authenticity is 'itself a product'?

22. According to the article, what is the central dilemma of content moderation?

PART D – VOCABULARY MATCHING [8 marks] Questions 23–30

Match each word or phrase (23–30) to the correct definition (a–h).

23. filter bubble

a. the deliberate spread of false information with the intention to deceive

Answer: _____

24. surveillance capitalism	b. an environment in which one set of views is constantly reinforced and alternatives rarely encountered	Answer: _____
25. echo chamber	c. the tendency for societies to split into opposing groups that distrust and demonise each other	Answer: _____
26. disinformation	d. an economic system based on harvesting personal data to predict and influence behaviour	Answer: _____
27. deepfake	e. a personalised information environment created by algorithms showing only content aligned with existing beliefs	Answer: _____
28. astroturfing	f. the process by which social media gradually exposes users to increasingly extreme content	Answer: _____
29. radicalisation	g. a synthetic AI-generated video that makes someone appear to say or do something they did not	Answer: _____
30. polarisation	h. the creation of fake grassroots campaigns to simulate popular support for a position	Answer: _____

PART E — GAP-FILL [12 marks] Questions 31–39

E

Gap-Fill [12 marks — 1 mark per gap]

Complete the sentences using words from the word bank. Most sentences need more than one answer.

WORD BANK

filter bubble	echo chamber	misinformation	disinformation
algorithm	engagement	polarisation	radicalisation
surveillance capitalism	content moderation	confirmation bias	epistemic
democratic discourse	deepfake	bot	astroturfing
geopolitical	propaganda	tribalism	amplification

31	Social media platforms earn revenue through advertising, which means their _____ are optimised to maximise _____ rather than to promote accurate or constructive content.
32	The _____ traps users in a personalised information environment that reinforces existing beliefs, feeding into an _____ in which _____ is systematically amplified.
33	The MIT study found that false news received 70% more _____ than true stories — primarily through human sharing, not automated _____ accounts.
34	The distinction between _____ and _____ matters because the latter involves organised, strategic manipulation — closer to _____ in the traditional sense.

35	_____ — synthetic AI-generated videos — and _____ — fake grassroots campaigns — are among the most powerful modern tools for spreading deliberate falsehoods at scale.
36	Increased _____ makes _____ more difficult, because democratic compromise requires citizens to share at least a basic _____ foundation about what has actually happened.
37	The _____ dimensions of social media manipulation became impossible to ignore after the 2016 US election revealed sophisticated foreign interference operations.
38	The rise of political _____ — the view that political opponents are not merely wrong but evil — is one of the most alarming consequences of social media's _____ of outrage.
39	The decisions that platforms make about _____ are editorial decisions — determining what is acceptable speech for billions of people — yet they currently face little _____ accountability.

PART F — EXTENDED WRITING [4 marks] Question 40

40. The writer argues that the current situation — in which social media platforms control the most powerful information distribution systems in history with minimal democratic accountability — is 'not sustainable'.

Write a paragraph of **80–100 words** giving your own view. Do you agree? What, if anything, should be done — and by whom?
